

GRAPPLING WITH A CONCEPT

How to Think Clearly, Speak Wisely, and Respond Faithfully

GRACIOUS PERSUASION SERIES



WHY THIS MATTERS:

We live in a world full of strong opinions and weak thinking. This guide gives a simple, repeatable pathway to pursue truth with clarity and grace.



QUESTION:

How do we move from confusion to conviction without becoming argumentative?



STEP 1 — CLARIFICATION

What do you mean?
Define terms.

"Help me understand what you mean by that."



STEP 2 — UNDERSTANDING (COMPREHENSION)

What are you saying?
Restate and confirm.
[Involves What is being said.]

"So what I hear you saying is..."
[Stating claim in simplest, clearest form]



STEP 3 — EVALUATION

Is it true?
Test logic and reasons.
[What are the arguments and evidence?]

"How did you come to that conclusion?"



STEP 4 — IMPLICATIONS (EFFECTS)

Where does this lead?
Trace consequences.



STEP 5 — RESPONSE

What should I conclude?
Agree, disagree, refine, or wait.
[Sometimes wiser to 'punt', give further consideration. Should be able to give reasons for any of these actions.]

TIME, PLACE, MANNER:

Is this the time, place or manner to have this discussion?



MEMORY LINE:

Clarify it. Understand it. Test it. Trace it. Then take a stand.

TEACHING GRID WITH SCENARIOS

SCENARIO	CLARIFICATION	UNDERSTANDING	EVALUATION	IMPLICATIONS	RESPONSE
 Truth is relative.	What do you mean by relative?	Truth depends on the person?	Does it apply to itself? Can anything be wrong?		Refine/ reject
 Christians shouldn't judge.	What do you mean by judge?	Condemning others?	Is that a judgment?	Can we make moral distinctions?	Clarify
 Science disproves God.	What do you mean by disproves?	Science explains all?	Can science test God?	Limits knowledge?	Refine/ reject
 Follow your heart.	What do you mean by heart?	Feelings guide us?	Are feelings reliable?	Leads to harm?	Refine
 People are basically good.	What do you mean by good?	People tend to be good?	Explains evil?	Societal impact?	Refine

HOW TO USE THESE CARDS

- Work through the steps in order.
- Ask the questions. Listen carefully.
- Respond with clarity, kindness, and confidence.

